Getting Started with Home Accounting

Note: If you have not read "Easy Accounting Concepts", **STOP**, and do that first, then return here.

Table of Contents

Section I: What this program is and why it exists.... 1
Section II: Home, Home on the Disk.... 2
Section III: So I'm in the Program. Now What?.... 2
Section IV: And Now?.... 3
Section V: Bank on it.... 4
Section VI: Everybody Wants *Money*—Your Vendor List.... 7
Section VII: Checking In—Recording Your Checks and Deposits.... 9
A Note on Vendors.... 11
Section VIII: Sharing the Blame—Distributed Debits.... 12
Section IX: Where Has All My Money Gone?—Budgeting.... 14
Section X: Holding Something Back—the Magic of Reserve Accounts.... 15
Section XI: I owe, I owe, So Off to Work I Go—Charges and Invoices.... 17
Section VII: Pay the Piper—Bill Paying.... 20
Section XIII: Bring Us Together—A Time for Reconciliation.... 21
Section XIV: House-cleaning—the Period-End Closing.... 22
Section XV: Program features.... 23
1. Fiscal Month Setting.... 23
2. Tracking Project Expenses.... 23
3. Designing a Check Form.... 24
4. Graphs.... 26
5. Supervisor-only Functions.... 27
a. Control Table Editor.... 27
b. Registry Entries.... 28
c. Security.... 29

Section I: What this program is and why it exists

Unless you are one of the 1% and have a staff financial advisor, you need to keep track of your money—it's that simple. Home Accounting (hereafter referred to as "HA") is an Accounts Payable program that's been specialized for a home user. It handles records of check and debit card transactions, open invoices/credit card charges and payments, both direct debit, and by check (remember those?). It maintains a monthly budget. It provides detailed reports on where your money has mysteriously vanished to each month. It tracks project expenses. To be fair, you'll

also use it to record deposits to your accounts, which is an Accounts Receivable function in a small business, but let's not quibble: you are *not* a small business!

Section II: Home, Home on the Disk

First you'll need to install the program. Great news! HA does not require a special setup program to run! The releases download will contain 9 files: Home Accounting.exe, CheckFormDesigner.exe, SiriusUpdateUtility.exe, PromptedTextBox.dll, Home Accounting Master.mdf.template, LICENSE.md, README.md, Easy Accounting Concepts.pdf, and Getting Started.pdf. Simply create a folder on your local drive, name it "Home Accounting" (or "Glarf" if that suits you better—the program doesn't care) and copy these nine files in to it. Add a shortcut to the .exe file and you're ready to rock!

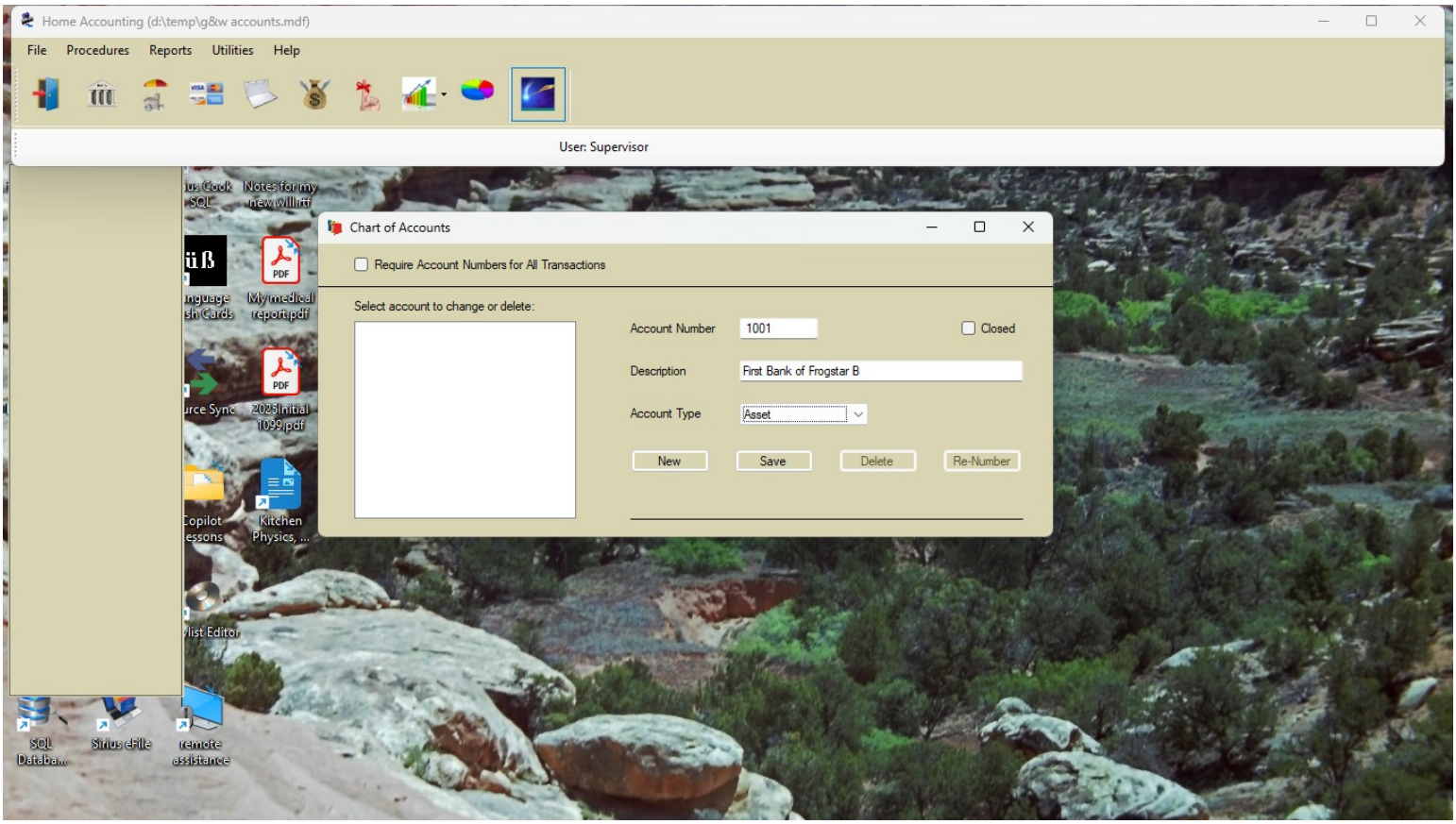
Note: this program requires SQL Server LocalDB to be installed on your computer, version 2019 or later. If you do not already have it installed, download it from the Microsoft website: SQL Server Express LocalDB - SQL Server | Microsoft Learn **and install it. If the installer fails, extract it and run SqlLocalDB.msi directly.**

Section III: So I'm in the Program. Now What?

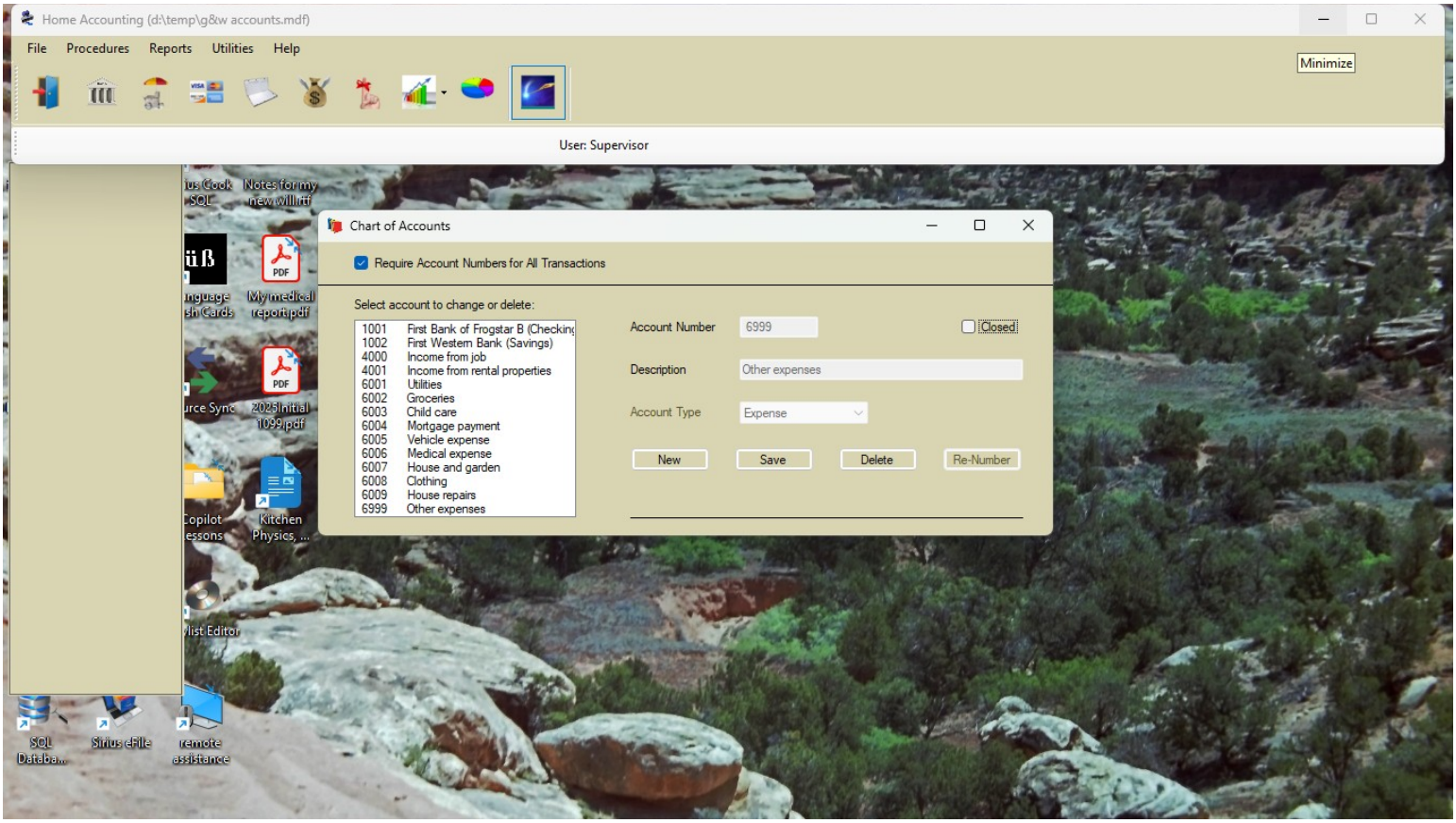
Now you need a database. So click **File→New Database**. In the dialog, tell it where you want the database and what to call it. HA will copy the database template into your new folder and rename it. Let's use the George and Martha example here: you just created a new database named "G&M Accounts.mdf". You will receive a message to log in to the new database as user "Super", with no password. The database will open (let's hope!) and you'll receive two messages about no budget being set up. You may safely ignore these: we'll set up a budget here in a bit.

Section IV: And Now?

Now you start entering your data. Because everything will need an account number from your Chart of Accounts, let's create that first. Select **File→Maintain Chart of Accounts**. This window appears:



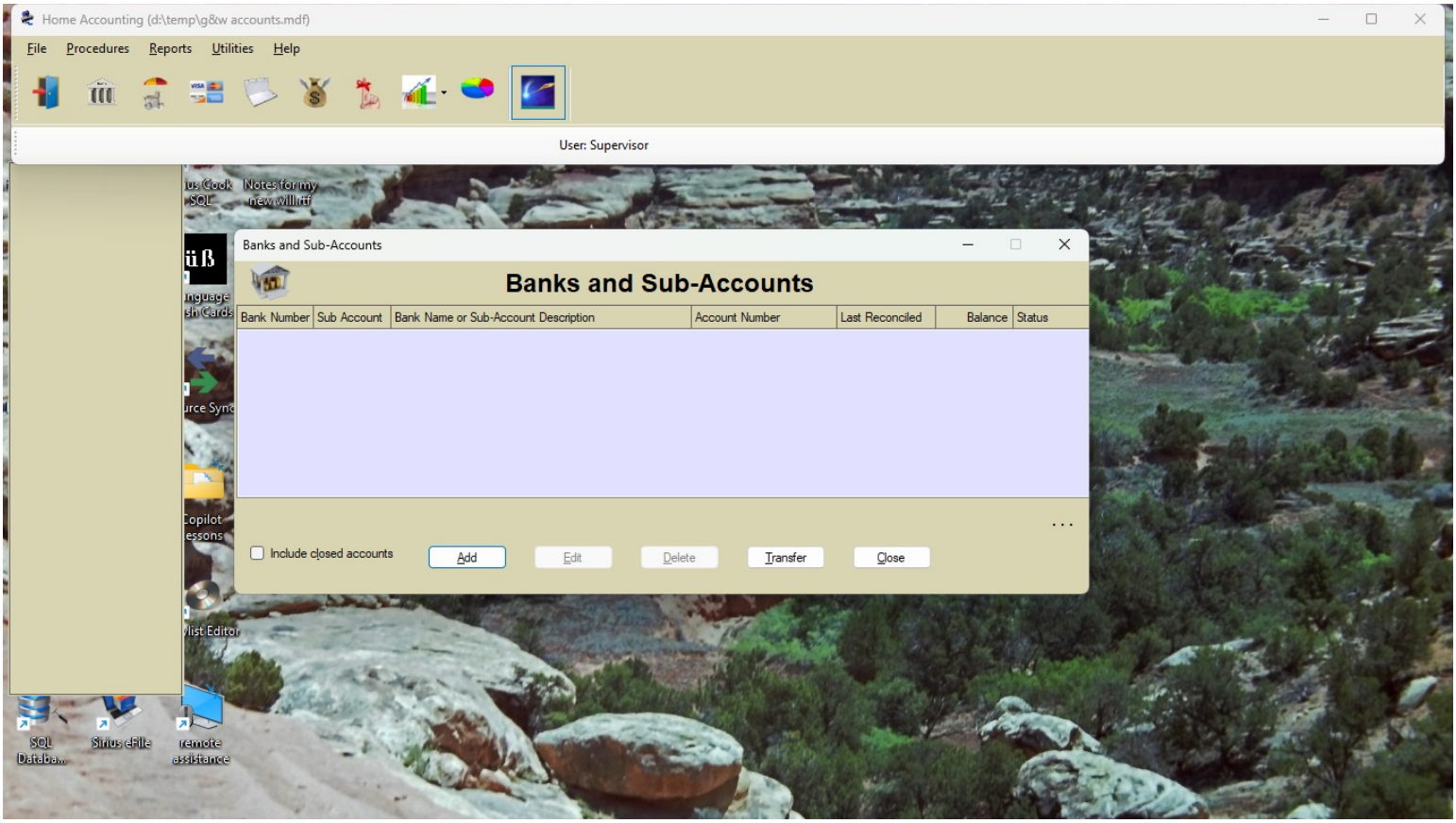
We'll follow the lead on the customary account number pattern, and give this account the number "1001", and account type "asset", because it's going to represent your first bank account. Continue developing your Chart of Accounts (take your time), adding all your assets in the lower numbers and expenses in higher numbers (you don't *have* to, but it's a wise practice you'll come to appreciate). When you're finished, you may have something like George and Martha's:



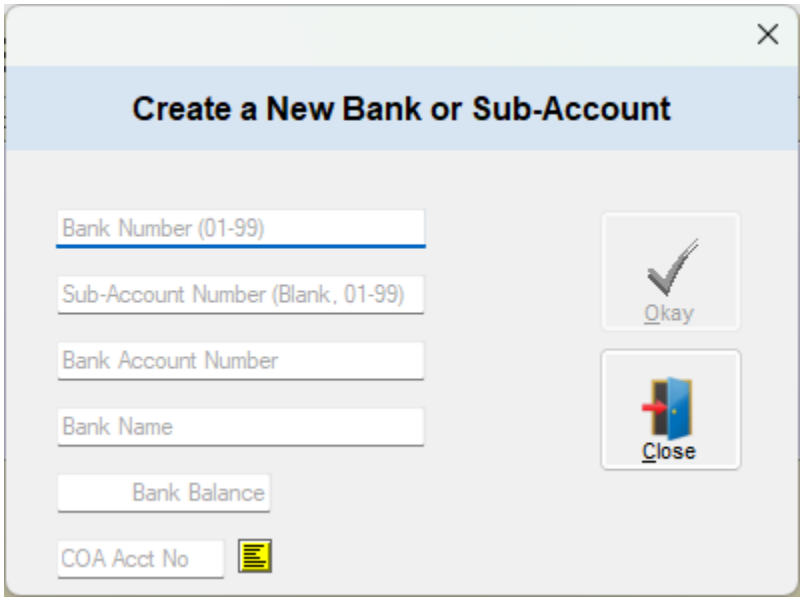
Check the "Require Account Numbers for All Transactions" button. You don't have to, but it's a safety feature: without account numbers, all your precious transactions will be just a mess of loose receipts in a drawer, so to speak. When you're done, close the window. You are well on your way, now!

Section V: Bank on it

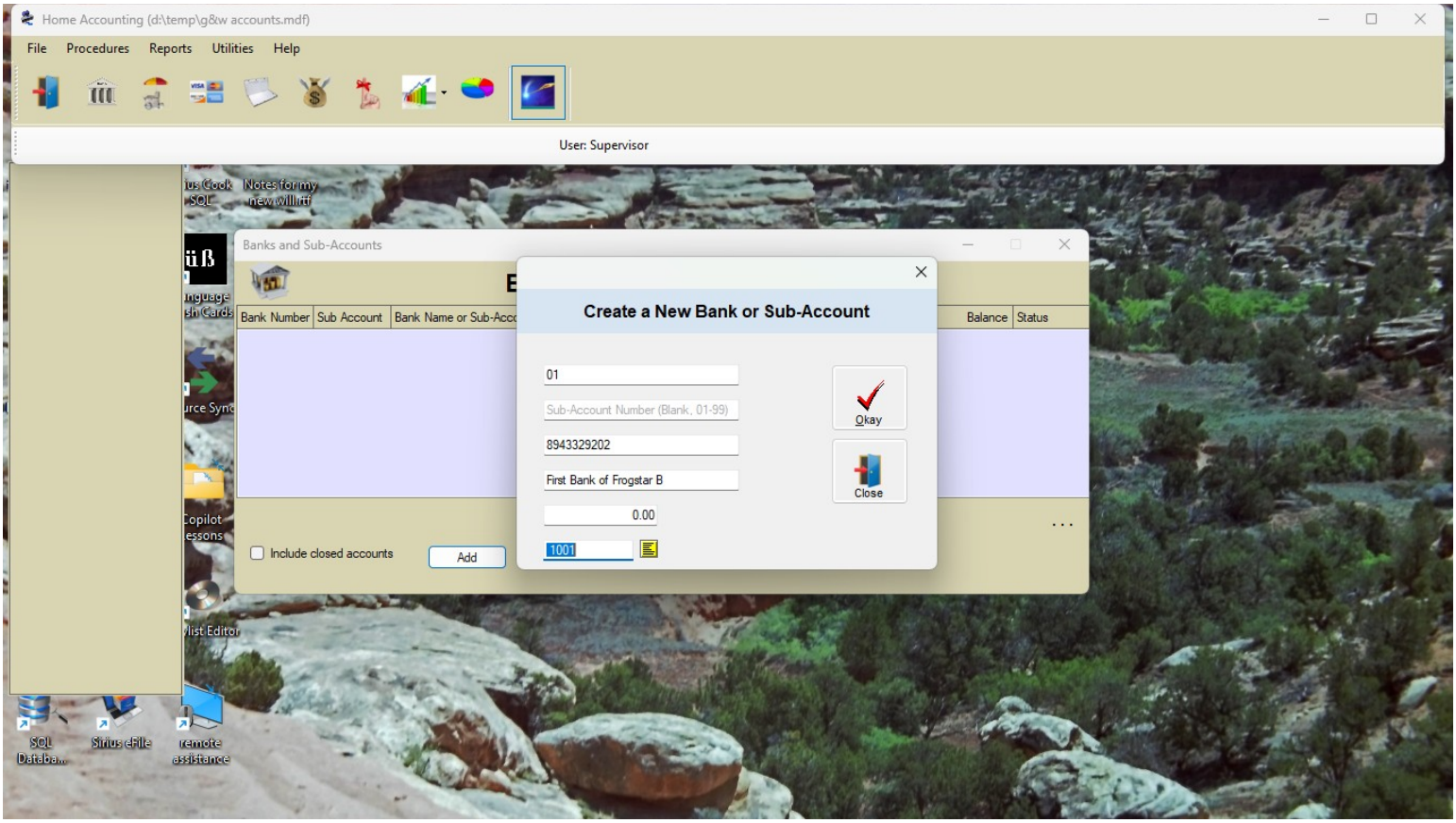
Now you need your bank account—or several. You might have a savings account: add it too. Let's create a checking account for George and Martha. Select **File→Bank Information**, or click the "Bank Information" button on the toolbar. This window appears:



Click the “Add” button. You’ll get this:



Fill in the information for your own bank. For George and Martha, we’ll begin with:

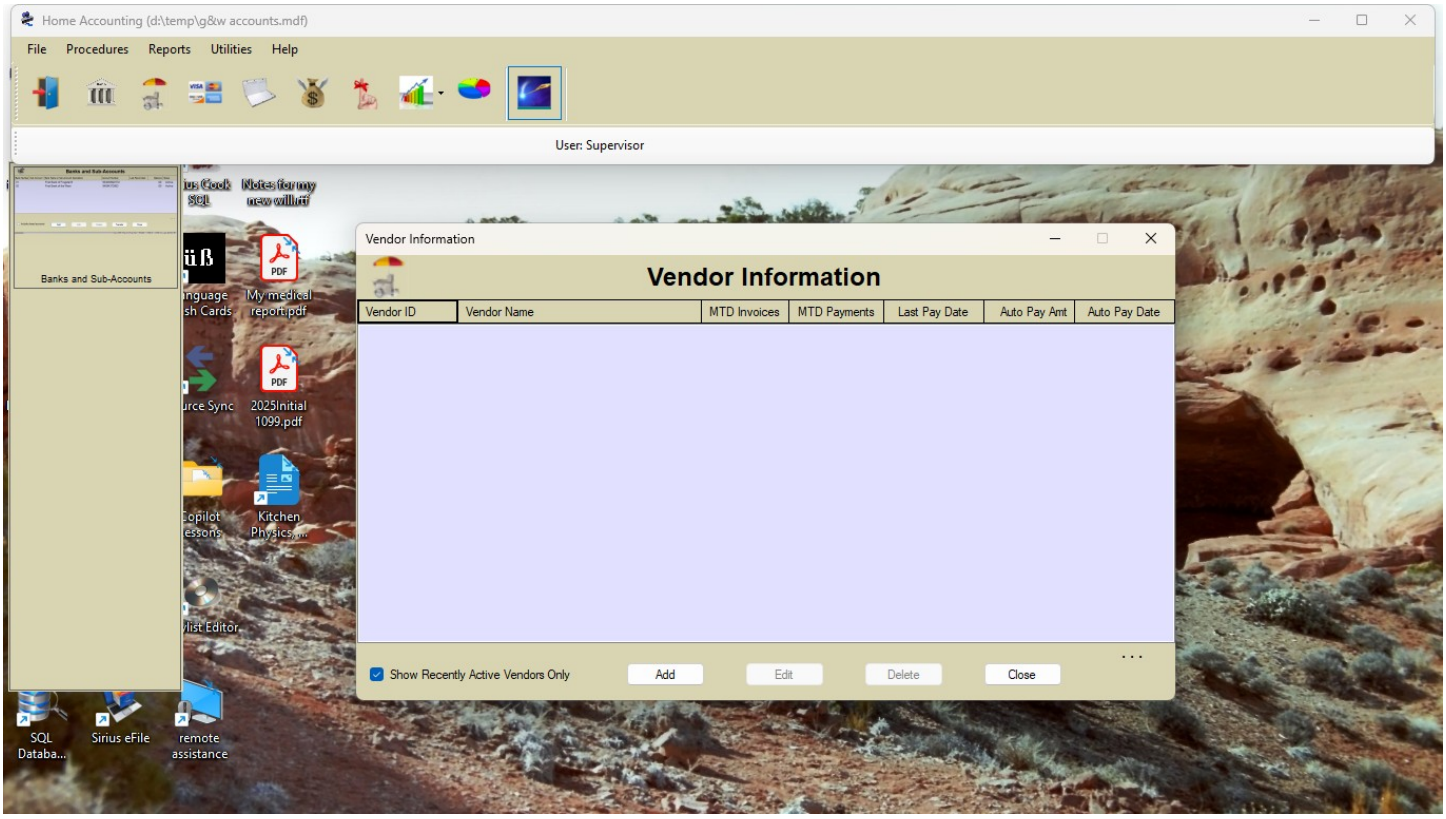


There are a few tricky parts here: bear with me. The bank number is a number from 01-99. It's used to select a bank to view when you record transactions (deposits, checks, etc.) The Sub-account number can be 01-99 as well. Sub accounts are used for what HA calls "reserve accounts" (technically a "prepaid expense"), but we won't go into that here and now. Leave this field blank. The bank account field is for the *bank's* account number—the one you see on your checks and bank statements. It's for information only. You may leave it blank if you feel safer. Fill in the name of the bank, e.g. "First Bank of the West". You won't fill in the bank balance at this point: leave it blank, or enter "0". Finally, the COA account number. This is the number you assigned when you created your Chart of Accounts. You can press F7, or click the yellow "lookup" icon to display your Chart of Accounts, if you don't remember the number you assigned. Save the record, which returns you to the parent form. Continue to add banks until you have entered all of them. And now the curtain opens upon…

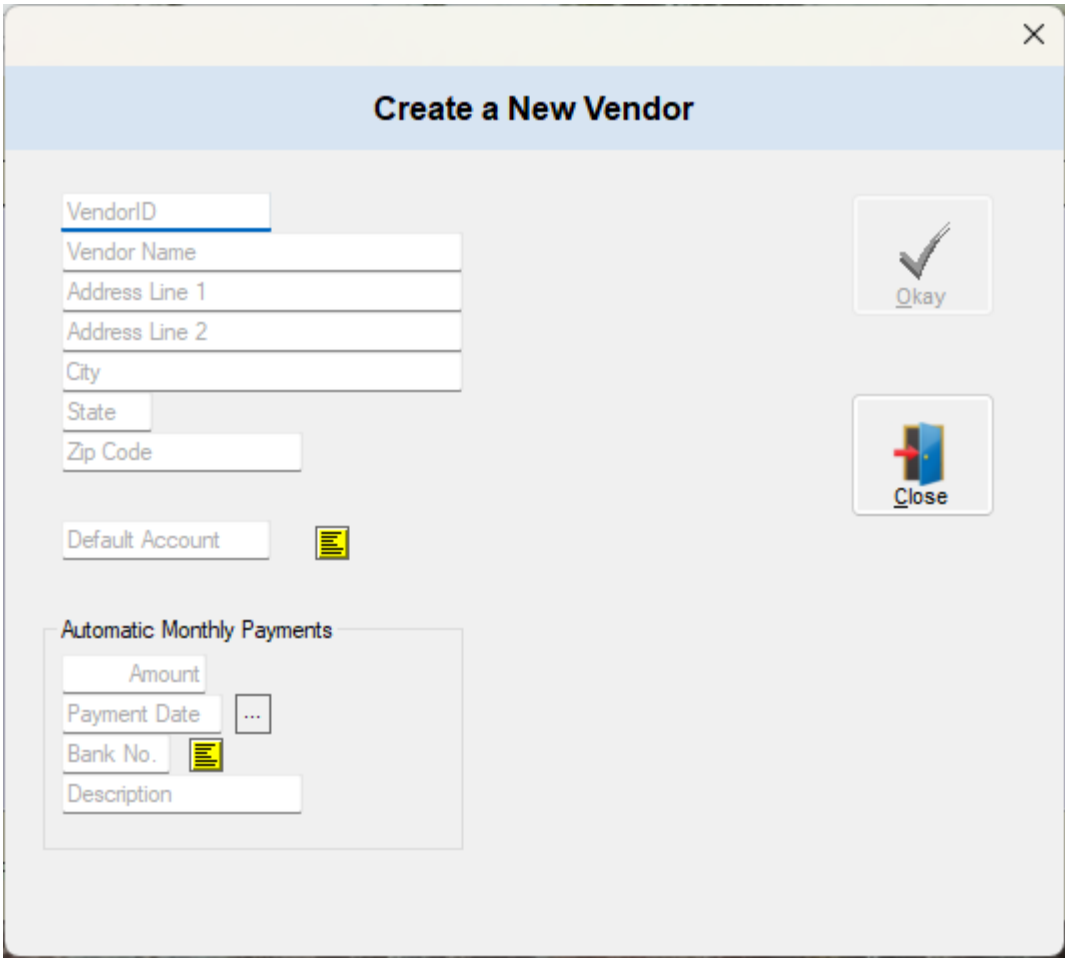
Section VI: Everybody Wants *Money*—Your Vendor List

This is the last task before you're ready to use HA. Every person/company to whom you have ever paid out of your accounts (previously entered) needs to have an entry in the Vendors table. A pain in the butt, but there's no getting around it, I'm afraid: you'll eventually want to see what you've paid out to your electricity provider, for example (and even show a graph of how much they've jacked up your bill over the last, oh, 5 years). 🙄

Select **File→Vendor Information**, or click the "Vendor Information" button on the toolbar. You'll see this form:



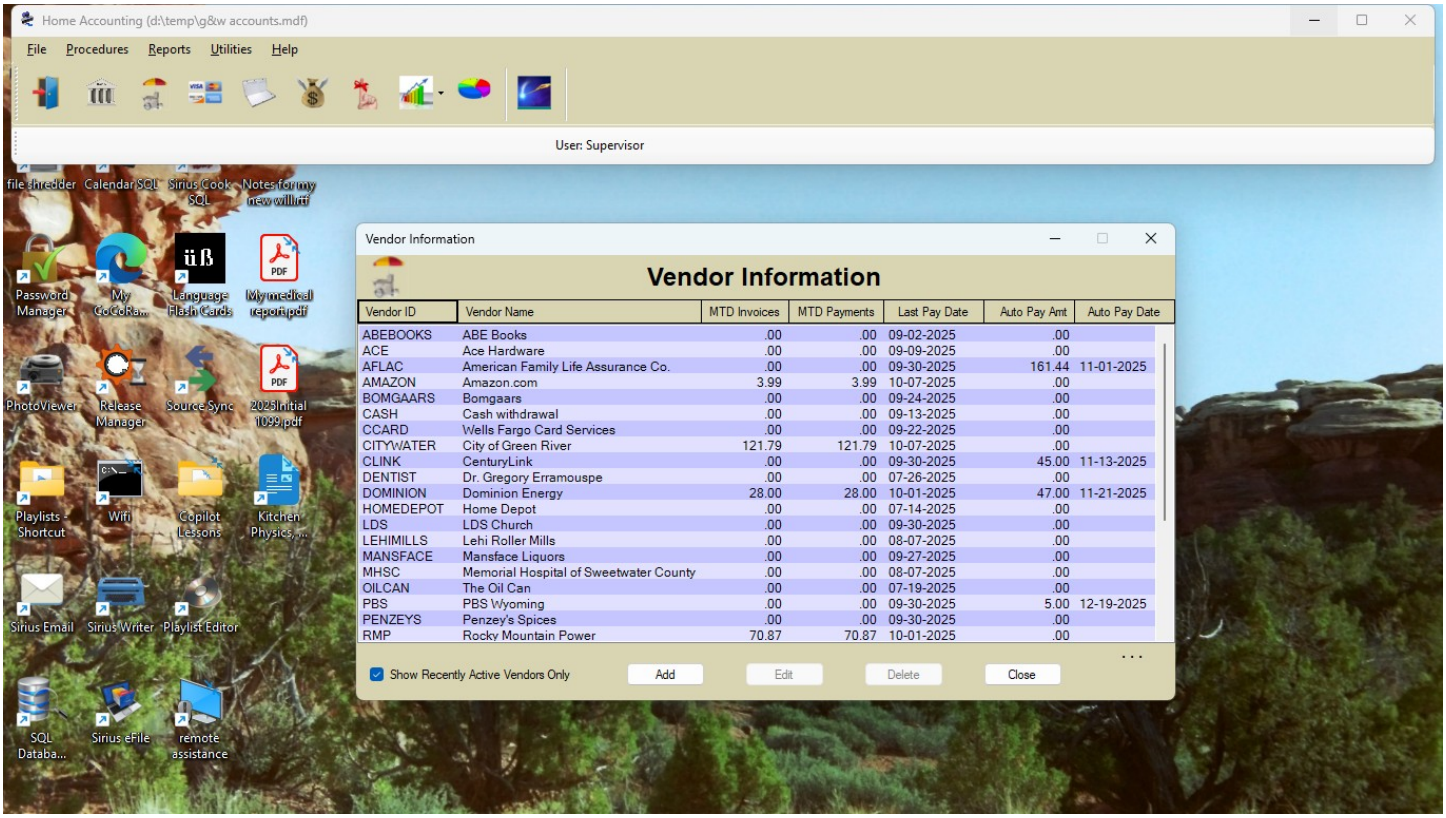
Click the "Add" button, which takes you here:



Here you'll perform the admittedly tedious task of entering the butcher, the baker and the candlestick maker. **However:** it is necessary to create vendor records through this route *only* if you need complete information, like their address or their account number for your business, or if you intend to set up automatic payments. You can create vendors "on the fly" just by *paying* them. This is discussed later on, when we discuss entering checks. All the fields in this vendor entry window should (hopefully) be all pretty obvious. The only fields you *must* fill in are the Vendor ID, Vendor Name and Default Account fields. The default account (which you may look up by clicking the yellow icon or pressing F7 in the field) is the **expense account** to which payments made to this vendor will be debited—by default. (You may override that account number at any time; so it should be the *most often used* account. For example, if you set up Amazon as a vendor, you might want to use your account number for "entertainment" as the default account, if your *most common* use is to buy books, music or movies). Vendors share the same account quite often: the electric company, the gas company, cell phone provider, ISP—all of these will likely take the account number for "Utilities". Perhaps you shop for groceries at 2 or more stores, or order them online from Amazon or Walmart: "Groceries". And keep in mind, this is only the *default* account number—the one

most commonly used. (You might use 6 or more just for Amazon: groceries, clothes, entertainment, etc.) Pick the account you'll need to override at entry time least often.

When George and Martha have entered all their vendors, they may see something like this:



Now, a note: like most people, you'll almost certainly have one or more credit cards. **You must set up each credit card issuer as a vendor. Their "default account" number should be set up in your Chart of Accounts as something like "Bank Charges".** The reason for this will be explained later, when we discuss credit card charges.

Section VII: Checking In—Recording Your Checks and Deposits

Congratulations! The worst is over, and you are ready to enter checks (nowadays more likely to be debit cards, but it's all the same) and deposits!

The very first thing you need to do is to record all your currently-outstanding checks and deposits. Once you have done this, *then* you can enter your current bank balance in your bank account record. If you do this correctly, when you get your next bank statement, your bank balance will match the bank's balance when you perform the monthly account reconciliation ("balancing your checkbook"). Let's take a look at where this all happens:

Bank Transactions

Bank Transactions

Bank	Type	Rec	Check	Date	Payee Name	Description	Amount
02	Ref	N		09-25-2025	Amazon.com	Refund	5.42
02	Chk	N		09-21-2025	Dominion Energy	Gas bill	47.00
02	Chk	N		09-23-2025	Amazon.com	Laundry detergent	21.37
02	Chk	N		09-24-2025	Amazon.com	Blower control module for truc	19.92
02	Chk	N		09-24-2025	Walmart	Groceries	35.78
02	Chk	N		09-24-2025	Amazon.com	Groceries	15.48
02	Chk	N		09-25-2025	Smith's	Groceries	12.99
02	Chk	N		09-25-2025	Smith's	Groceries	2.47
02	Chk	N		09-26-2025	Amazon.com	Canning salt	5.42
02	Chk	N		09-26-2025	Mansface Liquors	Creme de Cacao	17.00
02	Chk	N		09-27-2025	Smith's	Groceries	30.40
02	Chk	N		09-27-2025	Smith's	Non-food items	26.48
02	Chk	N		09-29-2025	Smith's	Groceries	29.17
02	Chk	N		10-01-2025	Wyoming Waste Services	Trash collection	113.22
02	Chk	N		10-07-2025	Rocky Mountain Power	Electric bill	70.87
02	Chk	N		10-13-2025	CenturyLink	Internet service	45.00

Add | Edit | Delete | Show Reconciled Checks and Deposits | . . .

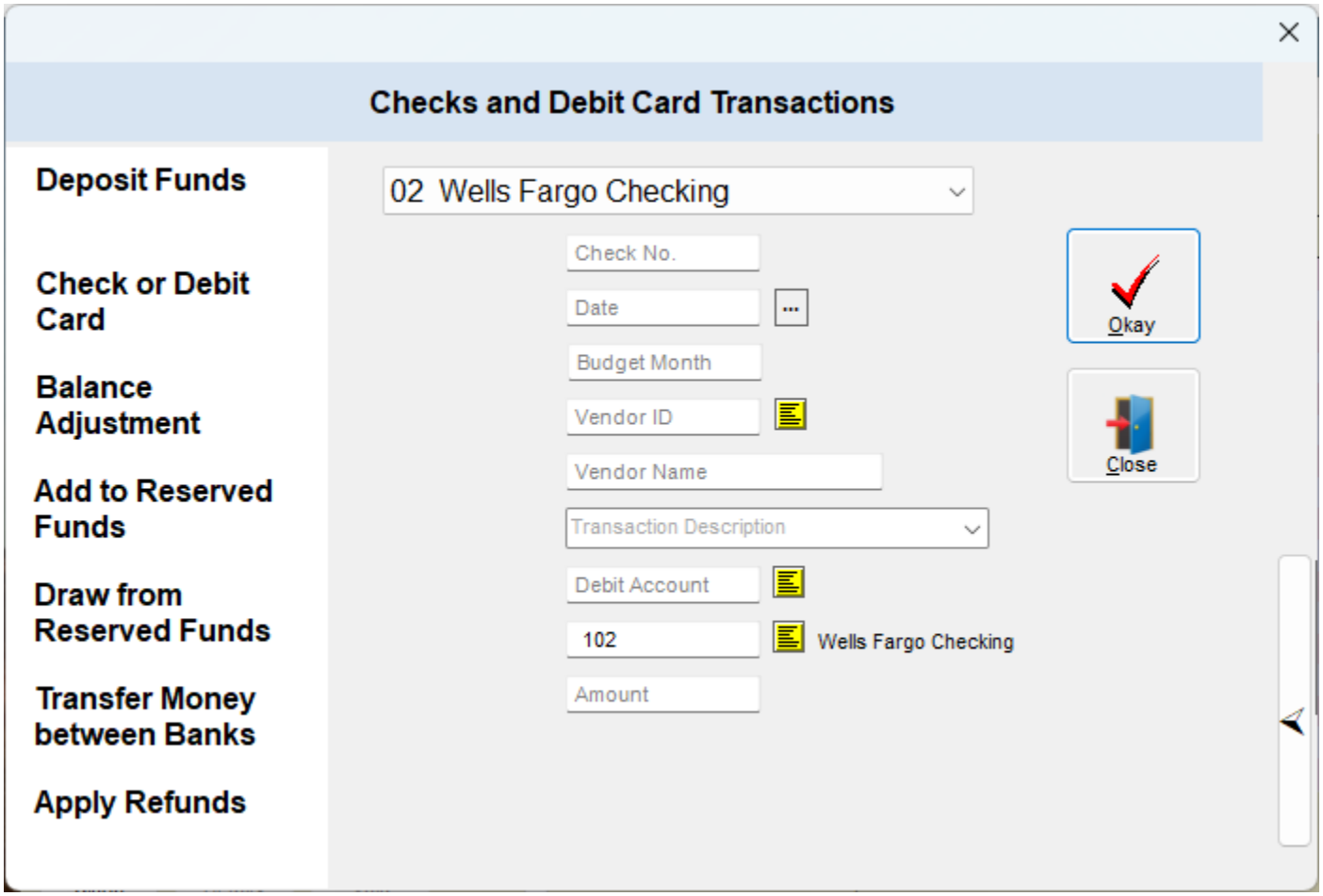
Close | Details | Void | Include Archived Checks and Deposits

Search All Payments

Apply Automatic Payments | Bank Number: 02 | Balance: $-81.96

Notice the "Bank Number" indicator. The program supports 1-99 banks, and the up-down indicator shows the current bank. Notice also the negative balance: you've been adding checks and deposits, to get your data entered, but have not yet updated the bank balance. That all comes soon. First, you must enter *all* your outstanding checks and deposits. *Then* you set the bank balance to what you know is your current balance.

To begin adding checks, deposits and other transactions, click the "add" button. This window opens:



You'll see there are seven different actions one can perform. Except for the two "Reserved Funds" actions, which we'll get to later, they should be self-explanatory. The drop-down listbox at the top shows the bank with which you are currently working. As discussed earlier, it is possible, in this window, to create a vendor simply by issuing a payment to them. If you enter a vendor ID, that does not exist, the program will alert you that it does not exist, and ask if you want to create it. If you say yes, a new vendor record will be created when the check posts, with the name you assign in the "Vendor Name" field, and using the "Debit Account" field value as the default account number for the new vendor. This feature vastly minimizes the number of vendors you need to create through the more formal process.

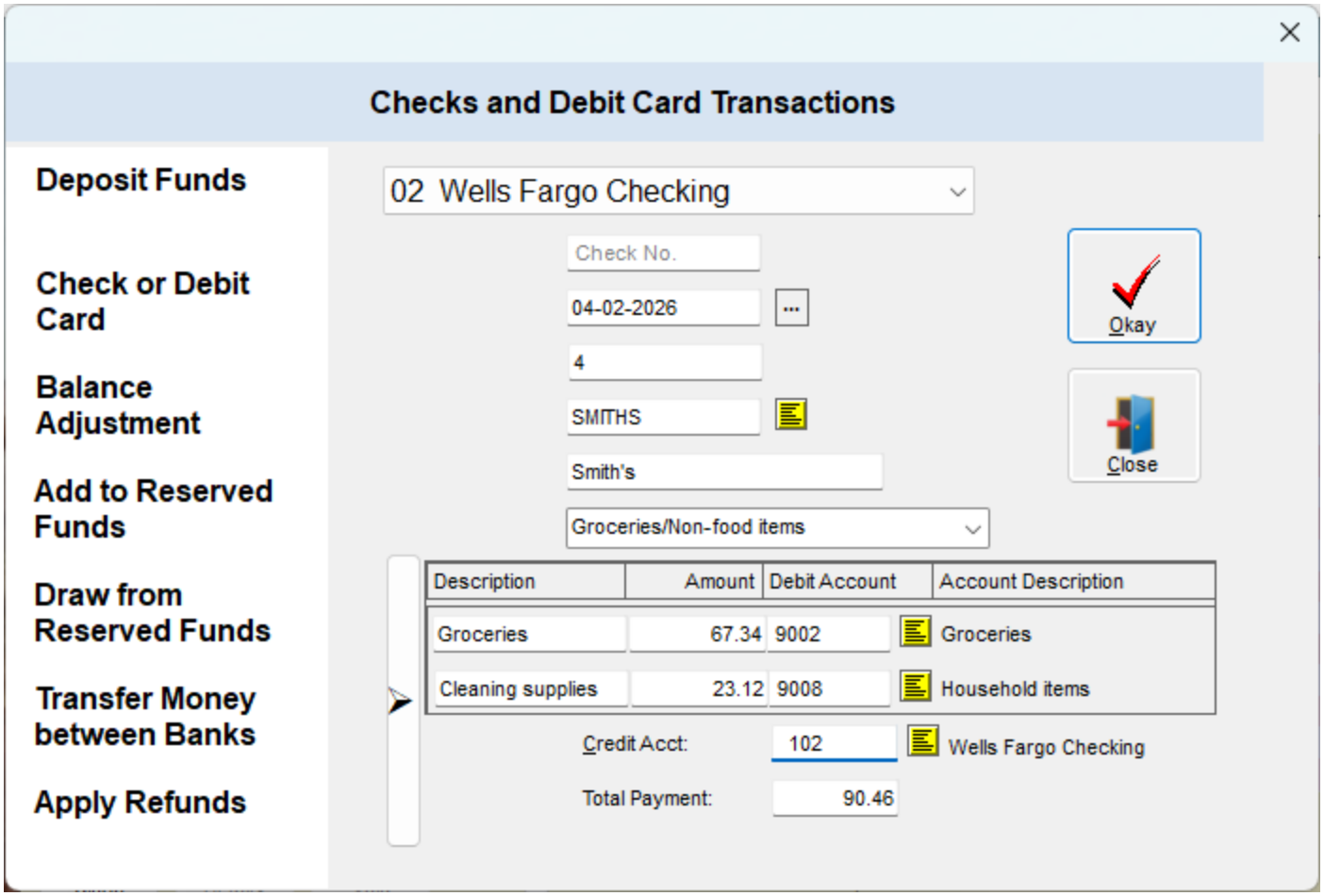
A Note on Vendors

After a long period of time (I've used this program for 23 years), your vendor list can become *quite* long. To minimize this, you'll notice a checkbox in the Vendor List window to "Show Recently Active Vendors Only". Checking that box causes the vendor list to show only vendors to whom you've made payments in the last 12 months. But if you uncheck it to find an older vendor, you may be overwhelmed by

the list of those with whom you've done no business for *years*. This has been addressed in the latest version of HA, with a "vendor retirement" feature. During the month Period-End Closing, any vendor to whom you've made no payment for 5 years or more is "retired": the vendor disappears entire from the Vendor List, vendor lookups, graphing and all other places. However, the vendor record still exists, and its Vendor ID is available in two places: when you enter an invoice or charge to a vendor, the auto-suggest Vendor ID field will show *all* vendor IDs, including retired vendors'. Likewise, when you record a check or debit against a vendor, all vendors' IDs appear in that autosuggest Vendor ID field as well. If you record an open invoice or credit card charge against a retired vendor, that vendor will be "un-retired" temporarily—until the next Period-End Closing, which will retire it again, unless the charge or invoice is paid. A vendor is only permanently "un-retired" when you have *paid* that vendor: an open invoice or charge restore the vendor only temporarily. This feature keeps your vendor list from becoming overcrowded with vendors with whom you've long since ceased doing business, while keeping your records intact.

Section VIII: Sharing the Blame—Distributed Debits

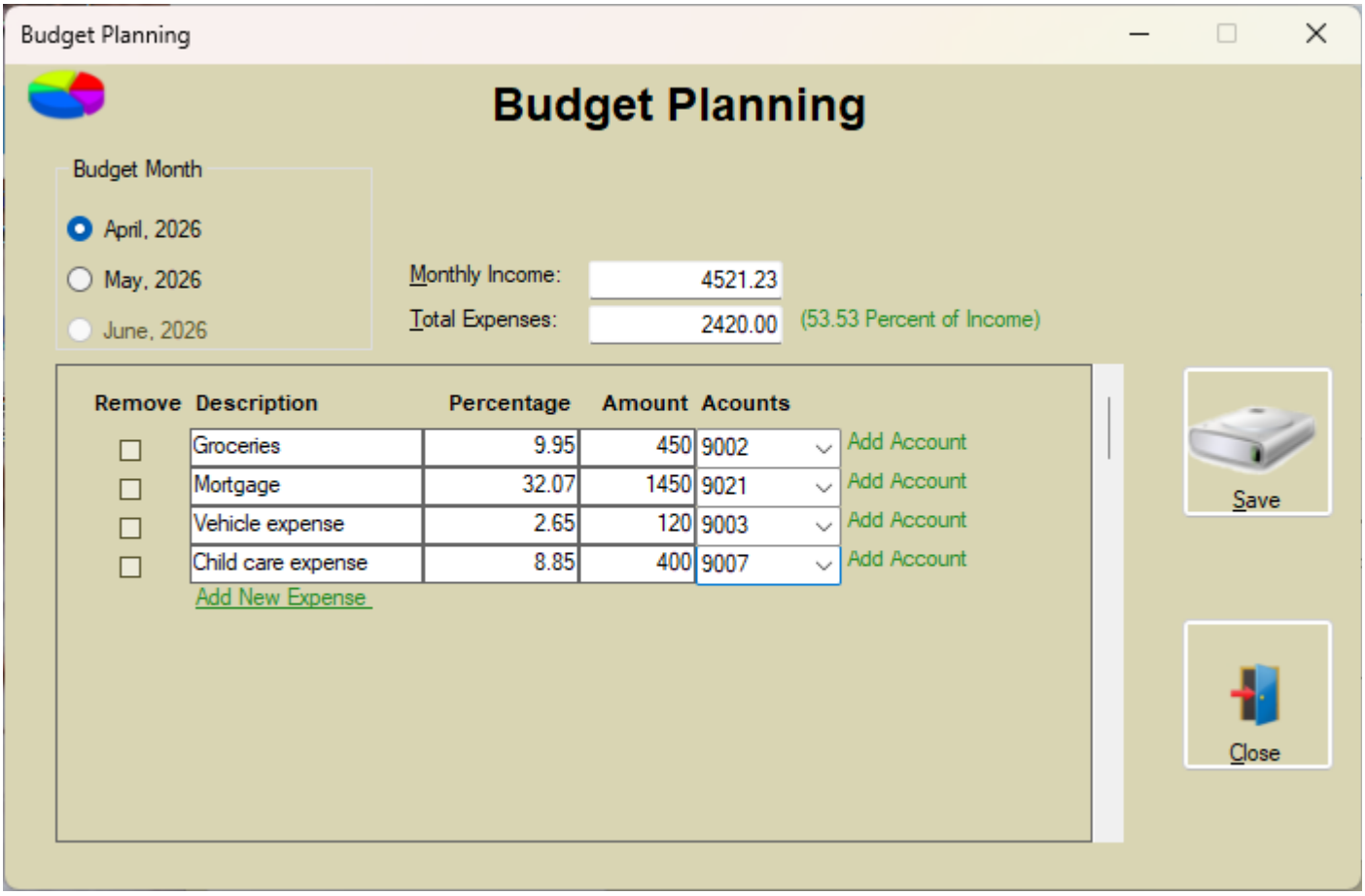
While entering a check/debit is often just a simple charge against a single account, like paying your electric bill, there are times when you spend money in a single place for items that actually need to be accounted for differently. As an example, you go to the grocery store and buy groceries, but you also pick up laundry detergent, glass cleaner, toilet bowl cleaner and sponges. These latter items clearly should not be charged against your groceries expense! For that, you can use the "Distributed Debits" sub-window. In the image above, notice the left-facing arrow in a white rectangle on the right-hand side of the data entry window. Clicking on this opens the Distributed Debits fields, as shown here:



Notice how in this example, George and Martha have just spent $90.46 at the supermarket. Of that amount, $67.34 was on groceries, and $23.12 was spent on various cleaning supplies. By breaking out these different *types* of purchases, one's budget can track those things on which you are actually spending money. After entering this distributed-debit transaction, simply click the now-right-facing arrow to close these supplemental entry fields. The reserved funds, transfer and refunds tasks will be discussed a bit later on. Now you need to begin, as just mentioned, entering in all the outstanding checks and deposits for the selected account. When you've done that, you can just open the bank record in the bank information window, and set your current balance. If you've not forgotten any checks or deposits, this will now reflect the actual state of your bank account. This will be verified when you run the monthly account reconciliation, at which time you can make any corrections required. Once you have entered all your outstanding checks and deposits, and updated your bank balance, you are ready to use HA to keep yourself on track! And the best way to do that is with a **budget.** So let's discuss how to budget.

Section IX: Where Has All My Money Gone?—Budgeting

There is an old stereotype of a series of jars sitting in a family's home, marked "Rent", "Groceries", "Utilities" and so on. Jars, envelopes, tins—all these things were really used to keep track of one's money. This is the idea behind a budget: only instead of a physical container, we divide money up by account numbers, maintained in your C**hart of Accounts.** Here's a modern look at those jars:



A budget can be as detailed or as general as suits your needs. You could have one account, as in the example above, for "Vehicle expense", or break it down into "Mom's Car expense" and "Dad's Pickup expense". You could have separate budgets for entertainment, dining out, travel, or just dump them all into an "other expense" category. Here's the thing: notice in the image above, the "Add account" link next to the drop-down list box. This lets you add multiple account numbers from your Chart of Accounts to a single budget category. Let us consider that "Other Expense" category. Let's say you allot $500 each month for discretionary spending. You still want to keep track of it, however, so you have accounts for entertainment, restaurant meals, road trips, perhaps even the occasional night out at your favorite bar. So you set up an account number for each of these, but since they

all count as discretionary spending, you want that money to come out of the same "jar", so you can set up a budget category called "Other Expenses", and add multiple account numbers to it. On the monthly budget report, thereafter, you'll see that lunch at your kids' favorite fast-food place, the money spent on the movie last Saturday night, the movie you downloaded for watching this evening—even though they are different expense categories, they all draw from a single budget "jar".

The HA program maintains budgets for 3 months: the current month and the two upcoming. Further, the budgets are propagated automatically from month to month, so you only need to review the budgets for those two upcoming months, and make necessary changes—almost never will every month's budget be identical to last, or next's. Perhaps you'll be traveling, so you can drop the amount in the groceries budget. Or you have a dentist appointment, so you need more money for medical expenses. Past months' budget reports can be viewed for a full year, and the upcoming month, via the "Monthly Budget Report". Be sure to set up a budget item for each reserve account you'll be using (Insurance payments, property tax payments, etc.) And now, let's discuss these "reserve accounts".

Section X: Holding Something Back—the Magic of Reserve Accounts

You have possibly thought, during this discussion of budgeting, but what about those big, but occasional expenses, like insurance or tax payments? Or variable expenses, like your monthly utilities? There's a way to handle those as well, built in to HA: the Reserve Account. For those of you with an accounting or bookkeeping background, these are technically "prepaid expense" accounts, but I prefer the term "Reserve Account", and here's how they work:

Let's pick two examples: one of a regular, but unpredictable expense like monthly utilities, and one of a once- or twice-a-year expense, like property taxes. In both cases, we handle them exactly the same: add up how much those expenses cost you, not in a month, but in a full year—and divide that amount by 12. Then, as just mentioned, you set up a budget category for that expense, with regular monthly additions of 1/12 (8.33%) of what you'll need over the course of a full year. Then, you set up a "Reserve Account" for your bank account, and each month you use the "Add to Reserve Account" feature of the checks and deposits entry window, shown above, to move money into that account. Your main bank account now shows that money as spent (hence the term "prepaid expense" used in accounting), but in fact it's still there in your bank account (possibly drawing interest), just hiding in the

reserve account until you need to draw upon it for that big, occasional, or just irregular, expense. And here's a hint: if you add a small amount *more* than merely that 8.33% each month, your reserve account will grow a bit of a cushion, for like when the insurance company sends you your new premium notice which just happens to have gone up (don't they *always*?). Granted, that bit extra will be easier for folks with a larger income than for a senior living on a fixed income, "nearer the bone". You can view the balance of each of these reserve accounts in the Bank Information window:

Banks and Sub-Accounts

Banks and Sub-Accounts

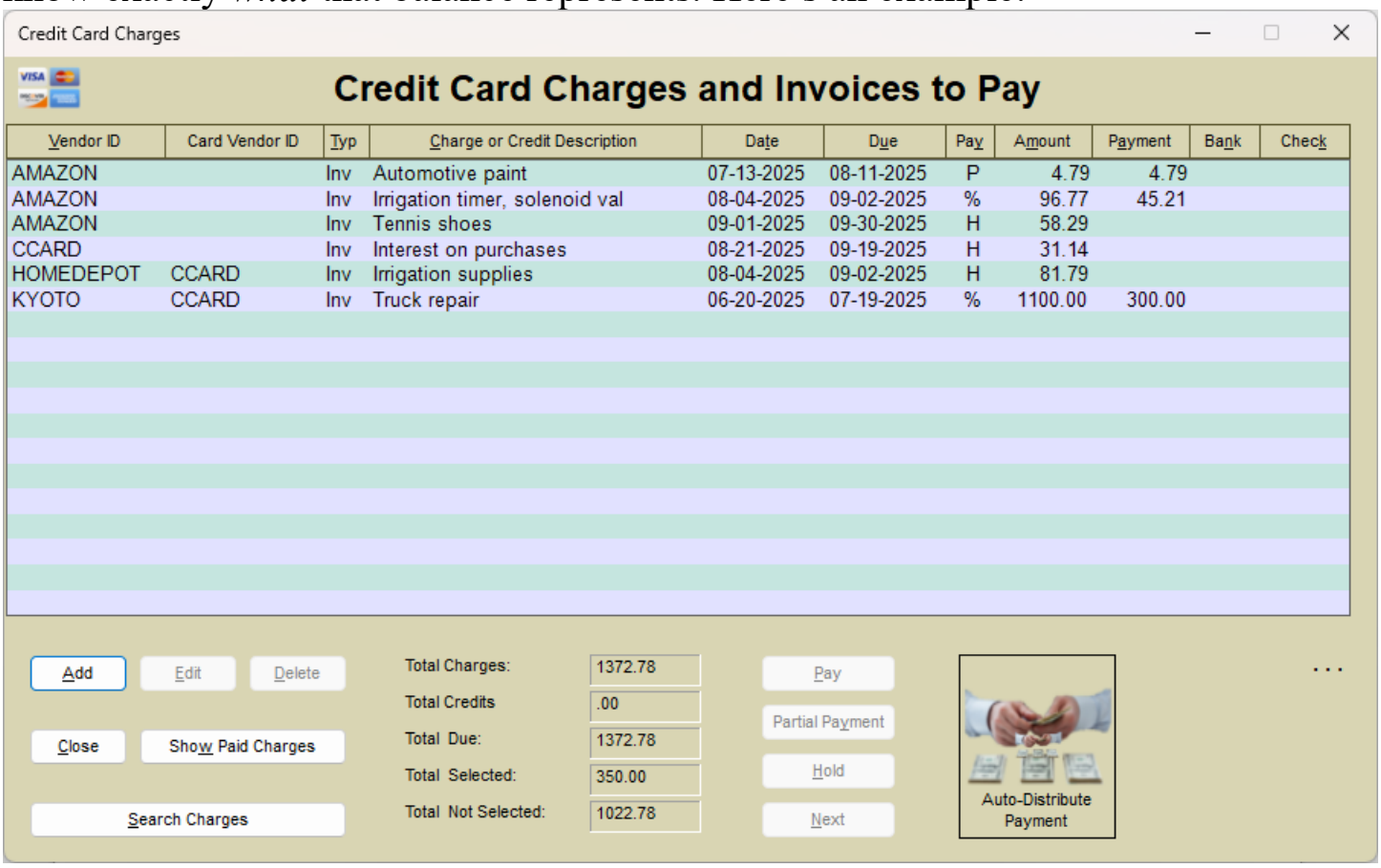
Bank Number	Sub Account	Bank Name or Sub-Account Description	Account Number	Last Reconciled	Balance	Status
02		State Bank - Checking	35283237282	09-30-2025	1734.90	Active
02	01	Reserve for Truck Insurance			225.00	Active
02	02	Reserve for Property Taxes and Insurance			1210.99	Active
02	03	Reserve for Dental Expenses			.00	Active
02	04	Reserve for House Maintenance			.00	Active
02	05	Reserve for Vehicle Maintenance			.00	Active
02	06	Reserve for Utilities			86.44	Active
02	07	Reserve for Medical Expenses			116.88	Active
02	08	Reserve for Prime Membership			43.78	Active

Include closed accounts Add Edit Delete Transfer Close

Notice that each of these listings are all bank "02", but except for the first, all have a sub-account number. You can set up to 99 sub-accounts per bank. You must also set up an account in your Chart of Accounts for each of these "reserve accounts". So, let's say your bank 02, "State Bank", is set up in your Chart of Accounts as "102"; you should set up your COA account for "Reserve for Truck Insurance", therefore, as "102.01", using the sub-account number. This keeps things neat and orderly and more intuitive. And remember, all the money in all of these reserve accounts *is still in your bank account*; it's just been earmarked for future use. This will not complicate your monthly account reconciliation: the reconciliation report accounts for these accounts automatically. As far as you're concerned, this money is already spent—but when the time comes to *really* pay that expense, you just create a "Draw From Reserve Funds" transaction—and you'll have the needed money.

Section XI: I owe, I owe, So Off to Work I Go—Charges and Invoices

Bills: like the poor, they are always with us. But HA can at least help you keep track of them. Remember, as discussed at the beginning, HA is basically an *Accounts Payable* program, so it knows how to handle payables. That is done in the "Credit Card Charges and Invoices" window. I have to warn you, this is the most complex function of the entire program. Why? Because credit card debt is where people get in trouble. If you look at a monthly statement, that says "Balance: $xxxx.xx" and you can't even *think* of what that was spent on, you're in trouble! And the best—the only—way to prevent such a disaster (the fodder of bankruptcy lawyers) is to know exactly *what* that balance represents. Here's an example:



Vendor ID	Card Vendor ID	Typ	Charge or Credit Description	Date	Due	Pay	Amount	Payment	Bank	Check
AMAZON		Inv	Automotive paint	07-13-2025	08-11-2025	P	4.79	4.79		
AMAZON		Inv	Irrigation timer, solenoid val	08-04-2025	09-02-2025	%	96.77	45.21		
AMAZON		Inv	Tennis shoes	09-01-2025	09-30-2025	H	58.29			
CCARD		Inv	Interest on purchases	08-21-2025	09-19-2025	H	31.14			
HOMEDEPOT	CCARD	Inv	Irrigation supplies	08-04-2025	09-02-2025	H	81.79			
KYOTO	CCARD	Inv	Truck repair	06-20-2025	07-19-2025	%	1100.00	300.00		

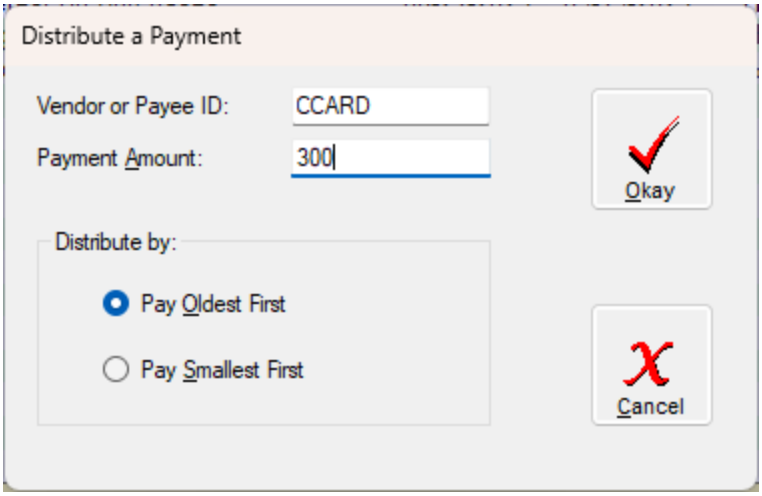
For HA, invoices are going to be a rarity: most vendors demand instant payment. Which is why the title of this form puts Credit Cards first. Look at this image, and you'll see the information that can help keep you solvent: what you owe, what you're preparing to pay, and what you'll still owe after you pay it. You should *always* know exactly what you're paying for, and how much, with every payment you make to "MyCharge Visa Extra"—or whatever. And the way to do it is to record ***every*** purchase made on credit, here, in this window. (*You must also be sure to record interest charges or credits each month!*) If you do this correctly, your

balance, as reported on the "Outstanding Credit Card Charges" report, will always match the balance your credit card issuer reports to the penny. So let's look at how this works:

Notice in this example, the vendor ID "AMAZON" and blank beneath the "Card Vendor ID" column. This indicates that you are making payments *directly* to the vendor (at least, to all intents and purposes: Amazon's store cards are serviced by a third party, but that need not come into play, as all charges are those made on the Amazon website). Then look at one entry to "CCARD" for "Interest on purchases." You *must* record interest charges each month, as they are also money you owe to the credit card issuer. Finally, we see two vendors: "HOMEDEPOT" and "KYOTO", with "CCARD" listed as "Card Vendor ID". What this means is that you used a credit card for purchases to these two vendors, and the money is owed, not to the actual vendor, but to the *Card* issuer. You *will* find these invoices listed in the vendors' "Account Status" windows, so you'll always be able to see what you purchased from whom: the credit card issuer is merely an agent to whom you'll repay the money with interest, and the vendors' "Account Status" window will show each invoice. (The Credit Card "vendor" window will also show all charges made using it. Refer to the section on entering vendors.)

Next, notice the "Payment" column. This is the amount you are preparing (each month, typically) to pay towards this debt: in our example, $350—$50 to Amazon, and $300 to the credit card issuer identified by "CCARD", for a total payment on debt of $350. Notice also, the buttons "Pay/Hold/Next/Partial". Marking an invoice as "Pay" will mark it to be paid by the next payment run (we'll discuss that shortly). "Next" means that, after the next payment run, that invoice will be automatically marked as "Pay" for the next payment cycle after. "Hold" means that you are not paying that charge/invoice yet. And, finally, "Partial" (represented by "%" in the list) means that you are paying *toward* that charge/invoice, but not the full amount. This is the usual case for credit card servicing.

Now Take a look at the big "Auto-distribute Payment" button. This is the easy way to apply your payment to the charges you've incurred. Click this button, and this small dialog appears:



In this example, George and Martha are going to make a payment of $300 on credit card "CCARD". Notice the options to pay the oldest first, or the smallest first. Normally, you'll want to pay the oldest first, so you can see the older charges drop off the list as they are paid off. **Note: these options probably do *not* match the order in which the credit card issuer applies your payment.** The card issuer will choose a legal method, but one which allows them to maximize the interest they charge you, like applying your payment to charges with a lower APR first. However, for your information, this is irrelevant: as long as you correctly and regularly enter a charge for the monthly interest charge, your balance will match that the card issuer reports each month.

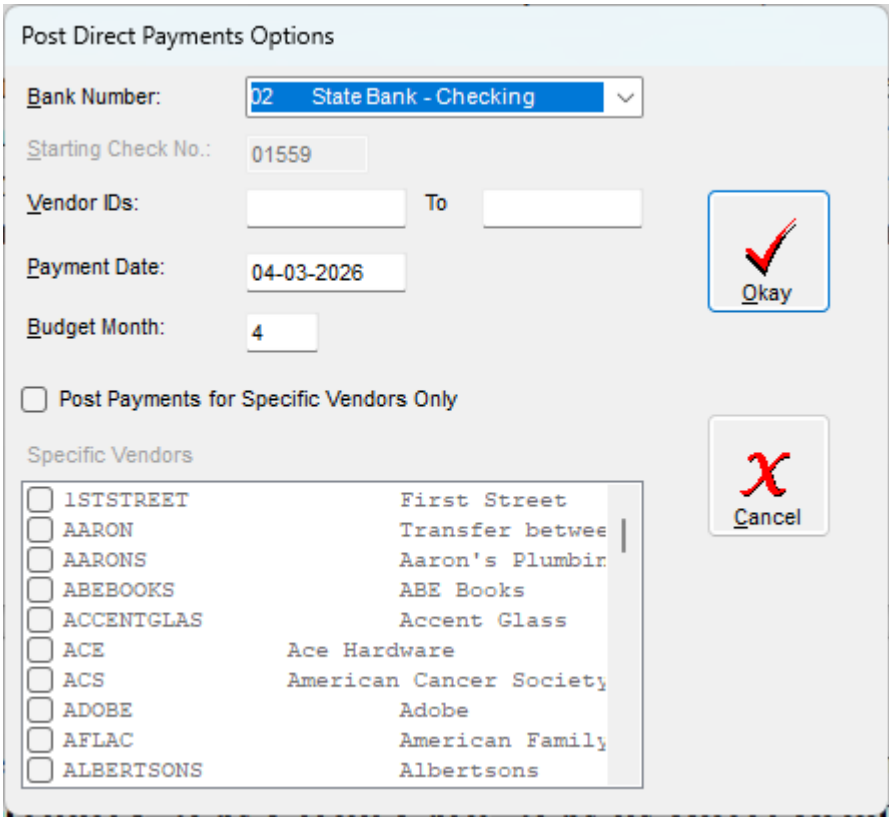
Now refer back to the main window, and you'll notice that George and Martha are planning on paying a total of $350 on debt service this month: $50 to Amazon and $300 to "CCARD". You can change the status of any invoice manually at any time up to when you actually pay them.

Other options in this window allow you to see paid invoices, including those that have been moved to the archive (invoices over 1 year old), as well as to search them ("Show me a list of all invoices with the word 'Repair' in them", for example.)

Once you have entered your outstanding invoices and credit card charges, and specified the amount to be paid on them, you are ready to actually record the payment. (While HA can actually print a check to the card issuer, it is more likely, nowadays, that you will be paying them online, in which case you only *record* a payment.)

Section VII: Pay the Piper—Bill Paying

To either print a check, or merely record a direct debit in payment of your selected charges, Go to the **Procedures→Pay Credit Card→Pay by Direct Debit** (or, alternatively **Pay by Check**) menu. You'll see this dialog:

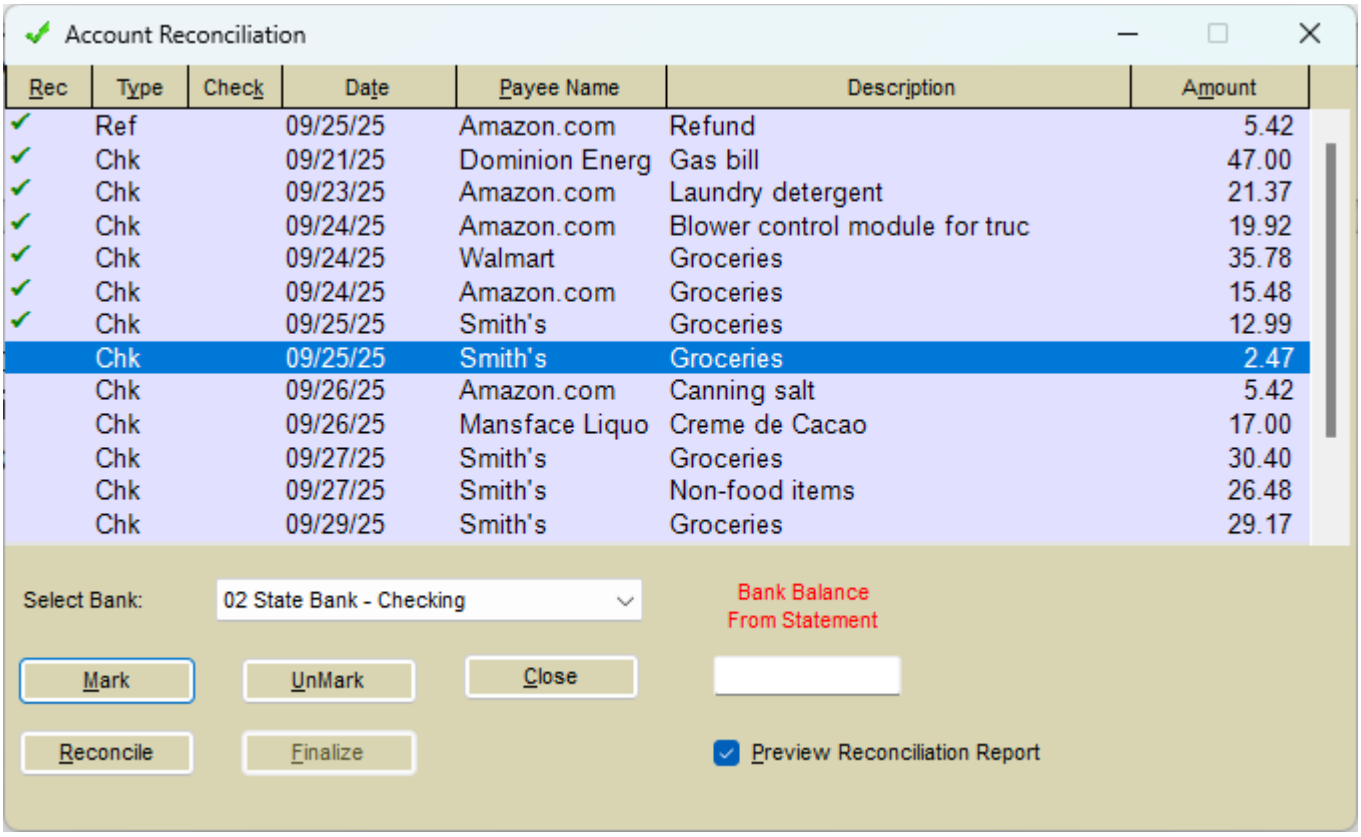


The Bank Number drop-down list box shows all sources of funds, including reserve accounts. For example, if you are paying an insurance bill, you might select a reserve account for insurance. Or property taxes. Or medical bills. Most times, however, you'll select your normal bank account. And despite the invoices you selected to pay, by specifying payment amounts as discussed above, you can select individual vendors to pay, and all others will remain queued for payment, but unpaid. Notice in this dialog, the Payment Date and Budget Month fields. You can specify the date to which the payment will post, even if it's not the current date, and the budget month will automatically follow. (The budget month is based on the day you specify as the first day of your budget month. For most people, this will correspond to the first day of the month; however, a retiree might specify it as the earliest day of the month on which his/her pension arrives. I do this myself, specifying the 22nd as the start of my budget month. So, in the case of April, any date from 23 March to 21 April is budget month 4; while any date from 22 April to 21 May is budget month 5. This is a *fiscal month*, whether or not your settings have

it correspond to a calendar month.) Once you have made your choices for the settings, click "Okay" and the program will record your payment (or print your check, if that's your choice).

Section XIII: Bring Us Together—A Time for Reconciliation

I've read that few people bother to reconcile their accounts any more. Oh my gosh: ***that*** is a perfect storm for overdrafts! And so, banks rake in *billions* of dollars in overdraft fees! This program is designed for people who value accuracy. What the bank shows as your "balance" at any give glance is seldom the *real* balance you have available. Unless you have so much money that paying out $30+ per insufficient-funds item doesn't matter to you, you *need* reconcile your bank accounts each month—that's why banks provide those statements. In theory, your actual balance—the amount you can *depend* on—equals the statement balance + deposits not shown – checks not shown. Admittedly, reconciling one's account is not as much fun as going to a movie; nevertheless, like taking out the trash, it really needs to be done. Don't become one of those who fall prey to financial carelessness. So, each month when you receive your statement, go to **Procedures→Account Reconciliation**, where you will see this dialog:

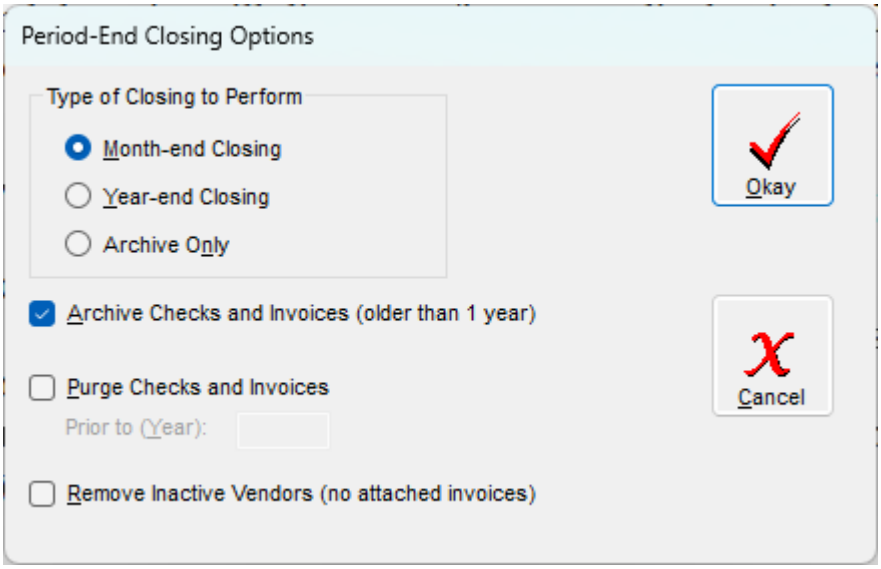


Rec	Type	Check	Date	Payee Name	Description	Amount
✓	Ref		09/25/25	Amazon.com	Refund	5.42
✓	Chk		09/21/25	Dominion Energ	Gas bill	47.00
✓	Chk		09/23/25	Amazon.com	Laundry detergent	21.37
✓	Chk		09/24/25	Amazon.com	Blower control module for truc	19.92
✓	Chk		09/24/25	Walmart	Groceries	35.78
✓	Chk		09/24/25	Amazon.com	Groceries	15.48
✓	Chk		09/25/25	Smith's	Groceries	12.99
	Chk		09/25/25	Smith's	Groceries	2.47
	Chk		09/26/25	Amazon.com	Canning salt	5.42
	Chk		09/26/25	Mansface Liquo	Creme de Cacao	17.00
	Chk		09/27/25	Smith's	Groceries	30.40
	Chk		09/27/25	Smith's	Non-food items	26.48
	Chk		09/29/25	Smith's	Groceries	29.17

HA makes this process as painless as possible. First, enter your bank balance as shown on your statement in the text box where indicated. Then, follow the listing of deposits and charges on your statement, and click "Mark" for each one displayed in the window, that appears on the statement. When you've marked them all, click the "Reconcile" button, and the reconciliation report will print or appear on the screen (if you select the "Preview Reconciliation Report" option, recommended). At the bottom, you'll see two numbers: you current account balance and your *reconciled* account balance. When they match, you can click the "Finalize" button. When they don't—well, sorry to say it, but then you're in for the painful tracking down of errors. It's the price of financial prudence. Once you've finalized the reconciliation, the reconciled checks and deposits will disappear from your display in the Bank Information window, though they remain in your database as reconciled items.

Section XIV: House-cleaning—the Period-End Closing

Along with account reconciliation, there is one other procedure performed regularly, but automatically: the Period-End Closing (PEC). When you first run the program after the start of a new month, you will be prompted to perform a **month-end closing.** When you first run the program after the new near, you will be prompted to perform a **year-end closing.** You should always allow this to take place —it only takes a few moments. The following options dialog appears:



Most of these options are set automatically. Click "Okay" and the process will run. During this process: 1) the MTD values (invoices and payments) for a vendor are

reset to $0.00. 2) At the start of a new year, the YTD values are reset to $0.00 as well. 3) Checks and invoices older than 1 year are archived (which keeps your list of checks lean). 4) Optionally can remove completely older checks and invoices (not advised, but it's your choice). 5) Optionally remove vendors for whom no single invoice exists. 6) Retires vendors for whom no payment has been made in 5 years.

Section XV: Program features

1. Fiscal Month Setting

HA offers the user the ability to define a *fiscal month*. For most people, this is going to be unnecessary. However, some people (notably retirees) get paid only once per month, and it makes sense to start your "month" when you get paid, rather than on the 1st of the month following. For example, Social Security, upon whom many depend, now pays on the 2nd, 3rd or 4th Wednesday of each month. I, personally, receive mine on the 4th Wednesday, which means "payday" can be as early as the 22nd or a late as the 28th. I, therefore, start my fiscal month on the 22nd of each month; thus 22 March becomes the first day of the April fiscal month (fiscal month 5). The monthly budget report then runs from the 22nd of a month through the 21st of the next month. If you wish to take advantage of the feature, go to **File→Properties→User Information**, and at the bottom of the tab, you'll see a field for Budget Month Start Day. Fill in the field with the day of the month you wish to begin a fiscal month, and click "Okay".

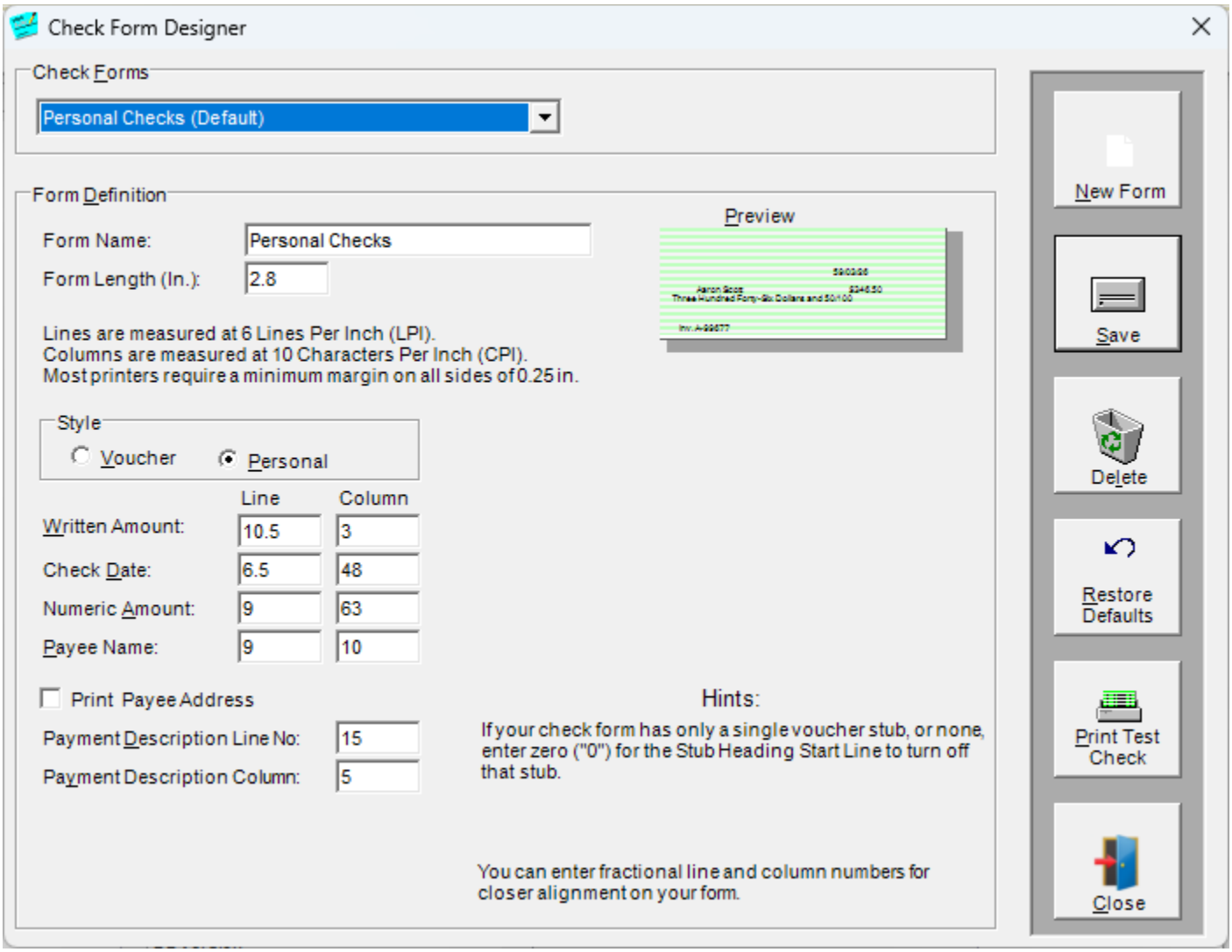
2. Tracking Project Expenses

One of HA's most useful features is the Project Expense Report. It's an easy feature to take advantage of. Reserve a region of account numbers in the Chart of Accounts (COA) for projects (I use numbers 10000 and above). Each time you begin a project: a remodel, for example, create a new account number just for that account. Thereafter, whenever you spend money toward that account, you can use that account number as the debit account number either when entering an invoice or charge, or an immediate check or debit. Then, simply select the **Project Expense Report** from the "Reports" menu, select that account number, and you will see a

report of all charges against that project, with a final total showing how much the project has cost you. You can optionally include unpaid invoices/charges, or not.

3. Designing a Check Form

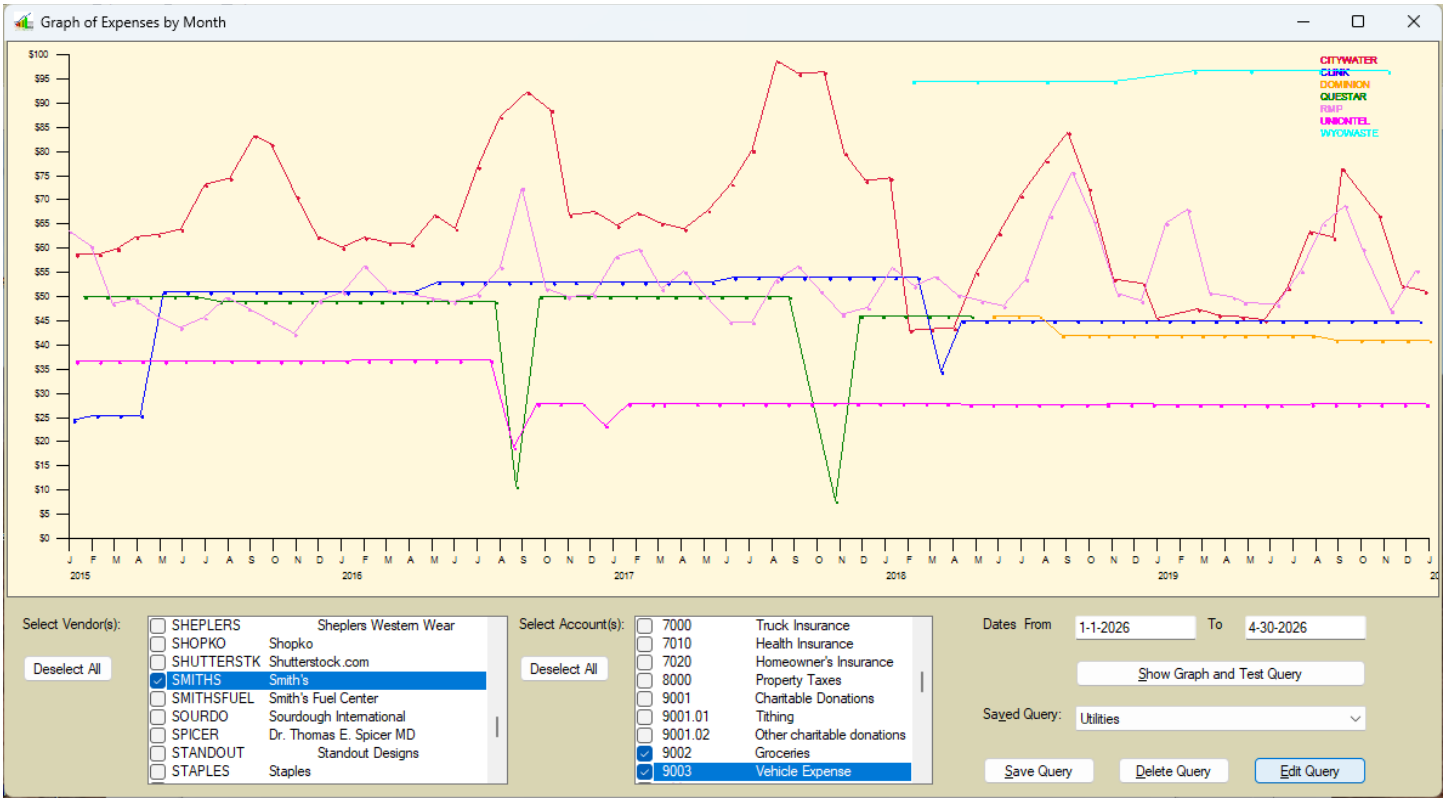
Remember checks? Those funny paper things that took so long to write out, while people in the checkout line behind you tapped their toes in impatience? Well, they haven't died out yet, and sometimes it's the *only* form of payment to be used: one might pay one's vehicle registration or property taxes or city water bill online, but with a "convenience fee" added for the overhead of the credit card processing. Check printing is an inherent ability of HA, and you can design the check form to match whatever checks you want to use: even personal checks, if your printer will feed them (my old one used to; my new one, no way!). Go to **Procedures→Check Form Designer** and this dialog appears:



Here you can design a form layout to choose your checks. When you have designed, tested and saved a check layout, go to **File→Properties→Check Printing Settings**, and select the printer and check form you wish to use. You can then use either the **Procedures→Quickcheck** option, or the toolbar button, to print a single check on the fly, or, when paying invoices and charges, use **Procedures→Pay Credit Card→Pay by Check.**

4. Graphs

Businesses *love* graphs. And because HA has roots in small business software, of course it can produce them. Two types of graphs are available in HA: a budget graph, and an expenses graph. Here is an example of the latter:

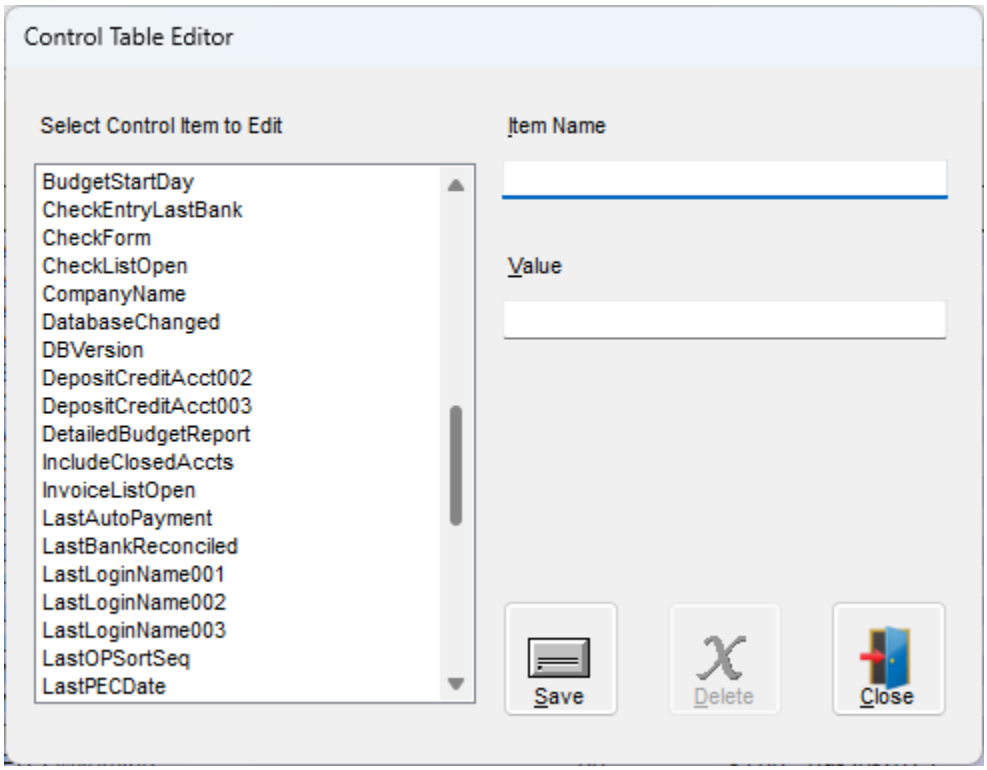


This is an area in which you can play around. Feel free to: I am not going to do any explaining of it, beyond showing this example.

5. Supervisor-only Functions

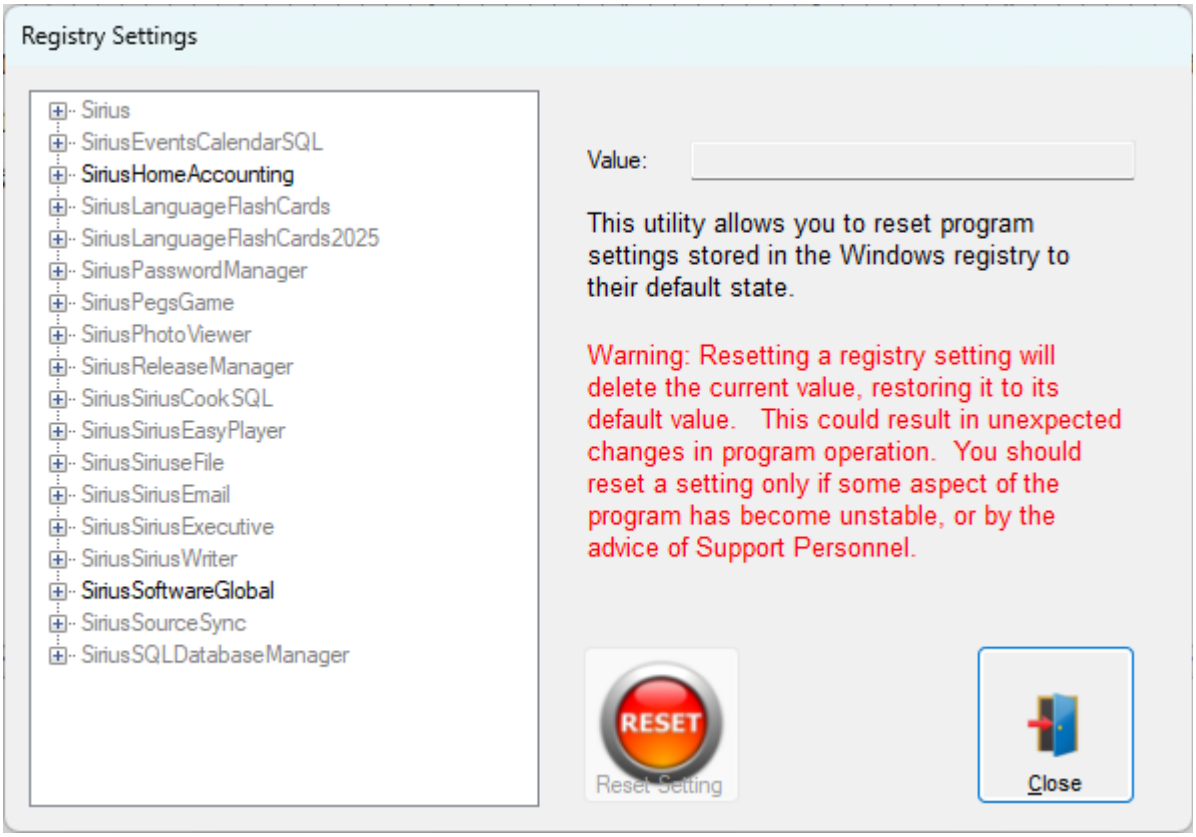
a. Control Table Editor

The Control Table is the primary "memory" of HA: it remembers settings, when you last performed certain tasks, and whether or not certain features appear. It is available *only* to the logged-in supervisor (who most likely is yourself). It is available under **Tools→Control Table Editor**. It shows only "memory" stored in the database, so is available only when the database is open. It looks like this:



It is advisable to leave this feature alone: at the very least, if you choose to explore and/or make changes, *be sure you have a current backup of the database*. Changes made here, unless specified in this document, could have, uh, *unpleasant* consequences.

b. Registry Entries



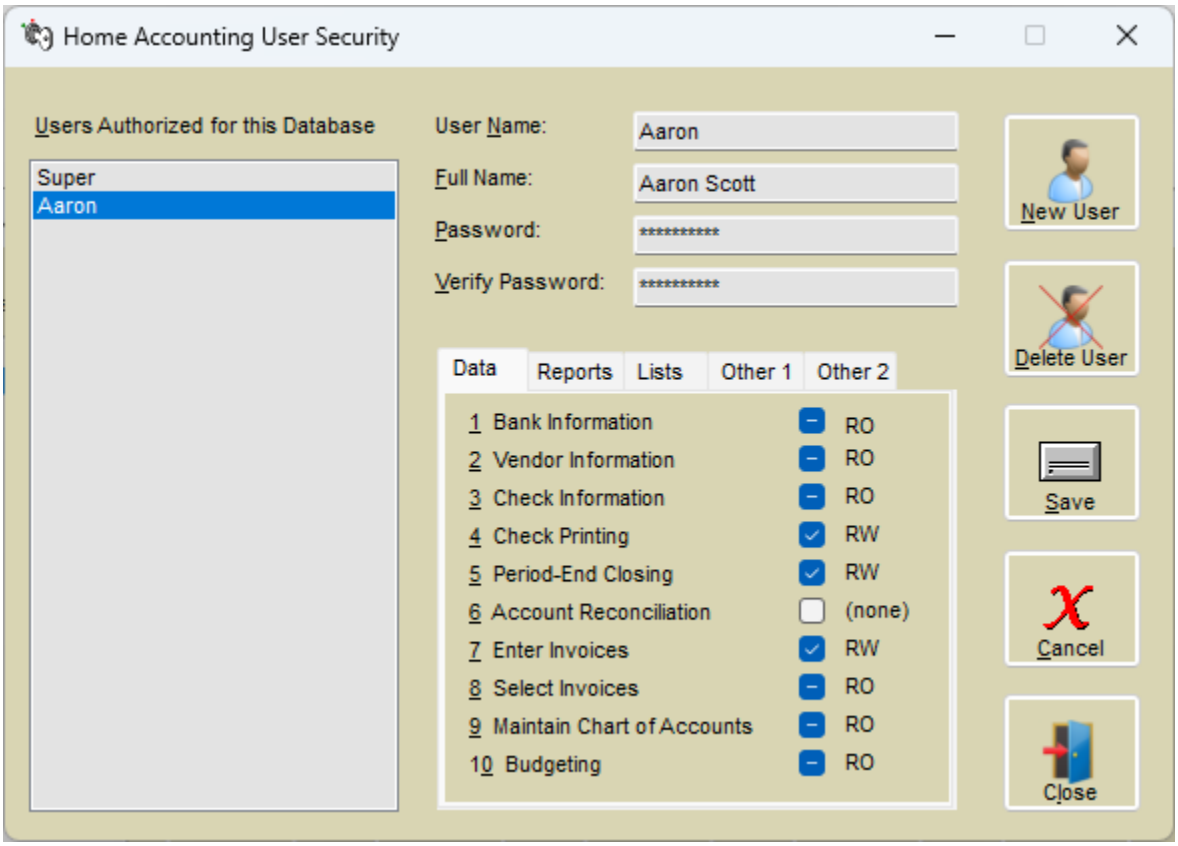
This feature, like the Control Table Editor, is available only to the Logged-In supervisor. It enables one to reset, but not to change, values held in the Windows Registry. While you can *view* the settings for any Sirius Software program installed on your computer, you can *reset* settings only for the program you are running. The same warnings that apply to the Control Table Editor apply here: it's best to stay away, except in cases explicitly specified in this document.

c. Security

HA incorporates two levels security: basic, which simply specifies authorized users, and enhanced, which specifies what particular actions an authorized user may perform, and with what rights: Read/Write, ReadOnly or None. By default, HA uses basic security (authorized users only); however, the supervisor may set the program to use enhanced security by adding a key/value pair to the control table. For enhanced security, add the key "SecurityType", with a value of "0". (See the section on the Control Table Editor.) If making this change, be sure to make no other changes to the control table, and *always* have a current backup of the databasebefore attempting any changes at all to the control table. Here is what the basic security dialog looks like:

As you can see, it simply defines authorized users and they passwords. If a user forgets his/her password, the supervisor can *change* or reset the password, but cannot *see* it. For a home accounting system, this is all you should need. But, as HA has roots in business accounting, it also can implement advanced security, as discussed above.

Here is what advanced security looks like, if enabled:



There are a total of 50 functions that may be defined in a program, and each may have Read/Write, ReadOnly, or No rights. For example, specifying RO rights to, say, vendor information, allows the user to look up vendor information, but not to add, delete or change vendors. Assigning “none” means the user cannot even open the vendor information window. This kind of security is total overkill for home accounting, but HA can implement it, if desired.